Regarding Rafael, Politburo member, Paul Verne, recommended that the state should ‘rule out further inquiries’ but added, ‘it is another matter that we instruct a comrade to talk to Karl-Eduard von Schnitzler or his wife about their offence’.

Rafael screamed innocence, saying she knew nothing of the theft, which she claimed was a deliberate provocation by the FRG. Her defence: the stockings had ‘been planted’ in her bag. She justified this with the fact that she had been interrogated in West Berlin by ‘people from the secret service’. Honecker’s approach, as you might expect, was to quietly sweep the entire saga under the rug. Der Schwarze Kanal continued uninterrupted. (Incidentally, Wolf Biermann’s song the Ballad of the corrupted old men – put von Schnitzler on a level with GDR hierarchs Honecker, Mielke and Hager.)

As more citizens presented submissions for official emigration, Honecker classed applicants into two groups. One of them, he bluntly stated, was ‘ideologically stubborn’, wanting to leave at all costs, while the other group applied for exit permits because of ‘personal conflicts, irritation and similar reasons’.17 The latter was by far the biggest group, and Honecker implored officials to ‘talk patiently’ with such aspirants to ‘make them withdraw their application’. He encouraged the establishment of so-called ‘coordination groups’ comprising of party, state and economic functionaries to handle every individual application.18

It was ironic, and yet deeply appropriate that memories of the Biermann debacle remained fresh decades later. ‘If one dirties his own nest and thereby favours others … let him stay there,’ Honecker huffily reflected in 1991. ‘I can still remember the dust was raised at the time. I regretted that in connection with this, so many artists turned their backs on the GDR. But, as I said, sometimes decisions are made in life which arise from necessity.’ These haughty and selfcomplacent remarks seem almost demented in the light of what happened, but Erich was not alone in his musings. Margot had known Biermann and his family since the 1940s. She had kept in contact with his mother for a long time, ‘and when Wolf Biermann became involved in the opposition, so-to-speak, I sought him out at his home and he sought me in my office,’ she explained, adding that by the mid-1970s, the